

Cabinet FEVER

The cabinet expansion may have earned him criticism, but Shivraj Singh Chouhan hopes that a revamped administration will help him in the crucial panchayat and municipal elections

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CHOUHAN HOPES TO GET LEVERAGE AGAINST HIS POLITICAL FOES FROM HIS NEW INDUCTEES

A man of consensus, Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan is known for his ability to keep away from any confrontation. The unflattering corollary of his efforts to take everyone on board was once again evident when the BJP's poster boy chief minister expanded his cabinet, taking the total strength to 33 with the induction of 10 ministers.

If Chouhan had his way, he would not only have expanded his Cabinet after the municipal and panchayat elections, but would also have avoided a few controversial names. Most of those who were accommodated last week boast of a powerful central leader's backing and it was their hectic lobbying which forced the chief minister to bring forward his expansion and include them. By giving min-

isterial berths to them, Chouhan has managed to keep the central leadership in good humour. He has bought their goodwill and trust and, of course, the loyalty of those who have been included in the cabinet.

The cabinet expansion, however, has been criticised, as four of the newly appointed ministers have a controversial track record. The inclusion of Tribal Welfare Minister